

The Way of the Shepherd

Seven Ancient Secrets to Managing Productive People

Kevin Leman and William Pentak

Companion Guide

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This guide spells out the full framework, including all seven secrets.

Quick Take

"The Way of the Shepherd" is a 128-page business parable you can finish in a single sitting (or a 2.5-hour audiobook on one commute). Kevin Leman, the Birth Order Book psychologist, teams with management consultant and former pastor Bill Pentak to deliver seven leadership principles through a story: a star CEO walks a young reporter through the lessons an eccentric professor once taught him on a sheep ranch. The verdict from readers is warm but split. It rates 4.36 on Goodreads across roughly 4,100 ratings, and fans call it one of the most useful leadership reads they have picked up. Critics counter that the "ancient secrets" are mostly well-dressed common sense that could fit in a magazine sidebar. Both are right. If you want a fast, memorable framework for treating the people you lead as whole human beings, and you do not mind a folksy metaphor, it earns its short page count. If you want rigor and nuance, you will find Patrick Lencioni's fables meatier. For a leadership team or a management book club, it is close to ideal: short enough that everyone actually reads it, and structured enough to drive real discussion.

About the Authors

The book is an odd and effective pairing. Dr. Kevin Leman is an internationally known Christian psychologist and New York Times bestselling author with a catalog north of 60 titles, almost all of them about family, parenting, and marriage rather than the office. He is best known for "The Birth Order Book" and the "Have a New Kid by Friday" series, and he has been a regular on The View, Today, Oprah, and Good Morning America. "The Way of the Shepherd" is the outlier in his bibliography: his one standalone business-leadership title. What he brings is his core competency, understanding how people actually tick, redirected from the kitchen table to the workplace.

The management substance comes from his co-author. William "Bill" Pentak holds an MBA from the University of Texas at Austin and describes more than two decades of revitalizing underperforming organizations. He is also a former pastor, which is the quiet key to the whole book: a shepherd metaphor (pastoral) bolted onto hard-nosed productivity management (corporate). One biographical detail gives the partnership some bite. Pentak was recruited out of business school and the pastorate by Enron, joining shortly before that company's famous collapse. He lends his own name to the book's fictional narrator, a cub reporter named Bill Pentak, blurring the line between author and character. If Leman supplies the psychology of people, Pentak supplies the lived experience of trying to lead them.

What the Critics Say

Reader reception splits along a predictable fault line for thin business fables. On the warm side, the book carries a 4.36 out of 5 on Goodreads across roughly 4,100 ratings and a 5 out of 5 across two dozen reviews on Christianbook. Enthusiasts praise its readability and its heart:

"The most profitable book, outside of the Bible, I have read this year."

Reader review, paraphrased

The skeptics are blunter. The most common complaint is that the substance is padded:

"The content here could have been covered in a seven-bullet magazine article."

Reader review, paraphrased

A recurring comparison in the negative reviews is to Patrick Lencioni: if you are going to read a leadership fable, several reviewers argue, read Lencioni every time. The other frequent objection is the central conceit itself. Casting employees as sheep strikes some modern, knowledge-worker readers as condescending. The honest summary is that this is a book whose strengths (warmth, brevity, memorability) and weaknesses (simplicity, the sheep metaphor) are the same trait seen from two angles. It does not pretend to be comprehensive, and your mileage depends on whether you read it as a primer or expect it to be the last word.

Themes and What Makes It Work

The engine of the book is a nested mentor story. A young reporter named Bill Pentak lands an interview with Theodore "Ted" McBride, the CEO of General Technologies and, in the book's framing, the most respected business leader in America after 17 straight years of success. McBride credits all of it to seven principles he learned 45 years earlier from Dr. Jack Neumann, an eccentric MBA professor. Just before graduation, as McBride was about to take his first supervisory job managing nine people, Neumann agreed to teach him "the way of the shepherd" through a series of Saturday meetings on his actual sheep ranch, using real sheep and real shepherding tools as the lesson. The wisdom passes from Neumann to McBride to Pentak to you.

That single sustained metaphor is what sets the book apart in a crowded genre. Where most business fables use abstract corporate settings, every principle here gets a concrete physical anchor: the flock, the pasture, the staff, the rod. Underneath runs a quiet thread of Psalm 23 ("thy rod and thy staff, they comfort me") and the biblical pastor-as-shepherd tradition. Within the narrative the religious framing is mostly implicit. It reads as a secular CEO-and-professor business story, which is exactly what lets it sell into both the general management market and the faith-and-work market.

The Seven Secrets, Spelled Out

Here is the full framework. Read together, the seven form a clean arc: know your people, fit them to the right work, connect with them, protect them, guide them, correct them, and ultimately care for them.

1. Know the Condition of Your Flock

Stay informed about the status of your people, not just the status of the work. Know them as whole human beings, their lives, dreams, and struggles, through real conversation rather than project updates. In practice this is Management By Walking Around: you cannot lead people you do not actually know.

2. Discover the Shape of Your Sheep

Match each person to the right role using the SHAPE acronym: Strengths (do they have the skills), Heart (is their heart in the work), Attitude (favor a can-do mindset), Personality (do they fit the job), and Experiences (what background equips them to excel). The book's memorable line: given a choice between talent and attitude, take attitude every time.

3. Help Your Sheep Identify With You

Build trust through transparency, integrity, authenticity, and consistency between what you say and what you do. Lead by example and set high standards, so people follow you because they want to, not because they have to.

4. Make Your Pasture a Safe Place

Create psychological safety. Keep people well-informed, give them visibility into where things are headed, address problems promptly, and root out the chronic troublemakers who poison the flock. When people are not busy protecting themselves, they can focus on contributing.

5. The Staff of Direction

The staff is the shepherd's gentle guiding tool. Direct people through persuasion and recommendation rather than coercion. Provide clear vision and boundaries while leaving room for autonomy, and keep looking ahead to spot opportunities before the flock wanders into trouble.

6. The Rod of Correction

The rod protects and corrects. It covers shielding the team from external threats, inspecting progress regularly, and using discipline as a chance to teach and restore rather than to punish. Accountability, in this telling, is an act of care.

7. The Heart of the Shepherd

The capstone that holds the other six together. Genuinely care for the people in your charge, be willing to sacrifice for them, and lead from authentic passion. The book frames it as a daily choice: every day you have to decide whether being a shepherd-leader is worth it. The real test of leadership is not setting the direction but getting the flock where it needs to go because it wants to follow.

What You Might Not Know

The professor's ranch is the whole point. Neumann does not lecture in a classroom; he hands McBride a job to do among real sheep. The tangible teaching prop, an actual flock and real shepherding tools, is what separates this book from peers that stay abstract, and it is why the metaphor sticks long after the details fade.

Two of the secrets are lifted straight from Psalm 23. The staff of direction and the rod of correction are the "thy rod and thy staff" of the psalm, recast as the two halves of leadership: gentle guidance and firm accountability. The book never preaches it, but the structure is scriptural.

Beware the fakes online. Several AI-generated summary sites have invented characters for this book, including a nonexistent "Marcus Chen, VP of Engineering." The authentic, source-verified cast is reporter Bill Pentak, CEO Ted McBride of General Technologies, and Professor Dr. Jack Neumann. If a summary names anyone else, it is hallucinated.

The Zondervan imprint is a clue to the strategy. Zondervan is a major Christian publisher, and the book was deliberately built to read two ways at once: a secular management parable on the surface, a scriptural shepherding model underneath. Pastoral reviewers read it through 1 Peter 5 and note that the word "pastor" comes from the Latin for shepherd. Corporate readers can take the same seven secrets as plain management practice and never touch the theology. That dual channel is the book's quiet commercial genius.

On the Page and In Your Ears

There is no film, television, or stage adaptation of the book, and there likely never will be. It is a framework, not a story with a plot to dramatize. (Note for searchers: a 2024 documentary short also titled "Way of the Shepherd" is about a Peruvian shepherd and has nothing to do with this book.) The one adaptation worth knowing is the audiobook, narrated by Marc Cashman and running about two and a half hours. That length is a selling point: it is a single-commute listen, which makes it easy to assign to a whole leadership team and have everyone arrive having actually finished it.

If You Liked This

Five reads that scratch the same itch, chosen for matching both the parable format and the people-leadership theme.

- **The One Minute Manager — Ken Blanchard & Spencer Johnson.** The original short business parable that taught managers a few memorable practices through a story. It is the direct ancestor of Shepherd's format and the obvious next read.
- **The Servant — James C. Hunter.** A businessman learns servant leadership during a week at a monastery. It is the most thematically identical title on this list: same narrative-plus-principles blend, same argument that real authority comes from serving.
- **Leadership and Self-Deception — The Arbinger Institute.** A corporate fable about "the box," the trap of seeing employees as objects rather than people. It pairs perfectly with Shepherd's seventh secret, the heart of the shepherd.
- **Lead Like Jesus — Ken Blanchard & Phil Hodges.** Explicitly uses the shepherd-and-servant metaphor with a faith frame. For the Christian-leadership audience Zondervan published Shepherd for, this is the natural companion.
- **Gung Ho! — Ken Blanchard & Sheldon Bowles.** Another animal-metaphor parable (squirrel, beaver, goose) on motivating people. Same easy-to-teach, easy-to-remember structure that makes it a clean fit for a management book club.

Go Deeper on the Metaphor

If the shepherd idea grabs you, three nonfiction companions build it out. Blaine McCormick and David Davenport's "Shepherd Leadership: Wisdom for Leaders from Psalm 23" is the closest secular companion, drawing leadership lessons directly from the psalm. Robert Greenleaf's "Servant Leadership" is the foundational text of the whole servant-leadership movement, broadening the idea beyond the shepherd image. And Timothy Laniak, who lived among Bedouin shepherds, supplies both the scholarly treatment ("Shepherds After My Own Heart") and a 40-day devotional ("While Shepherds Watch Their Flocks") for readers who want the metaphor with real field credibility behind it.

For Your Leadership Team or Book Club

Six questions built to provoke real discussion among practicing managers, not just to summarize the book.

1. Secret 1 asks you to know the condition of your flock. Honestly, how well do you know each of your direct reports right now, and what would it take to close that gap this quarter?
2. The book separates the staff of direction from the rod of correction. Which do you over-rely on, and what does that imbalance cost your team?
3. Secret 4, make your pasture a safe place, includes removing chronic instigators. Where is the line between protecting the flock and being too quick to remove people?
4. The metaphor casts employees as sheep. Where does that framing help, and where does it break down or feel condescending in a modern, knowledge-worker organization?
5. The heart of the shepherd claims leadership ultimately costs the leader something. What has your leadership genuinely cost you, and is that sustainable?
6. The book was written for both church and corporate audiences. Which of the seven secrets translates cleanest to our context, and which one needs the most reinterpretation?

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